

If You Only Watch One ICT Trading Video, Make It This (LIVE Trading): Summary & Key Takeaways — Glimpse

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ICT Trading Masterclass: From \$900K Payouts to Daily Consistency

Summary of the video "If You Only Watch One ICT Trading Video, Make It This (LIVE Trading)" by Chart Fanatics.

Desi Trades breaks down his complete ICT (Inner Circle Trader) strategy for capturing consistent profits through multi-timeframe analysis. He reveals how to identify liquidity sweeps, use fair value gap inversions as confirmation, and layer daily/4-hour/15-minute setups for high-probability reversals and continuations. The method scales from day trading (50-150 points daily) to swing trading to long-term leap positions, with real chart examples showing \$27K days and \$900K+ payouts.

Core Philosophy: Consistency Over Home Runs

Target Small Repeatable Moves, Not Massive Swings

Rather than chasing 500-point daily moves, Desi focuses on 50-150 point captures that he can execute day in and day out. This consistency compounds into six-figure monthly payouts and scales accounts reliably. The key is sizing down during high volatility and letting the points do the heavy lifting.

Be Reactionary, Not Biased

Desi trades what the market gives him rather than forcing a predetermined bias. This reactive approach has been the single biggest edge in his trading, allowing him to adapt to real price action instead of fighting it.

Data and Journaling Drive Confidence

Psychology matters more than technical skill. By recording every trade, journaling the journey, and building a personal dataset of 1,000–2,000 trades, traders can trust their system even through five-to-six-loss streaks. This data foundation is what separates profitable traders from those who quit.

The Multi-Timeframe Reversal Model

Daily Sweep → 4-Hour Inversion → 15-Minute Confirmation

The core setup stacks three timeframe layers: (1) Market sweeps monthly/weekly highs or lows (liquidity grab), (2) Creates a 4-hour fair value gap on the reaction, (3) Inverts that 4-hour gap (bias confirmation), (4) On the 15-minute, a bullish fair value gap forms during the retracement, (5) That 15-minute gap gets inverted on the 1- or 5-minute (entry trigger). Each layer must respect the previous one.

Fair Value Gap Inversion as Primary Confirmation

An inversion occurs when price breaks through a fair value gap (bullish or bearish) and then rejects it. For Desi, this is the highest-probability confirmation signal because it shows the market has changed intent. He pairs this with order blocks and previous resistance/support for extra confluence.

Prioritize Monthly/Weekly Liquidity Over Session Highs

When identifying draw liquidity (areas where traders are positioned), monthly and weekly highs/lows carry higher reversal probability than daily or session-level liquidity. Equal highs and lows stacked at these levels are especially high-probability reversal zones.

Day Trading Execution: Precision and Sizing

Entry: Market Execute on Lower Timeframe Inversion

Once the higher timeframe bias is confirmed (daily sweep + 4-hour inversion), Desi market-executes on the 1- or 5-minute inversion rather than using limit orders. This ensures he captures the move before it runs away, especially in high-volatility sessions.

Stop Loss Above 15-Minute High; Target at Prior Lows

The stop loss sits above the current 15-minute high to allow the trade to breathe and avoid whipsaws. The target is the prior sellside liquidity (often the 9:30 a.m. low on New York open or previous session lows). This typically yields a 1.5:1 to 2:1 initial risk-reward.

Trim 50% at First Target, Move Stop to Breakeven, Let Runners Go

Desi always trims half his position at the first take-profit level, immediately moves the remaining stop loss to breakeven, and lets the runners capture additional liquidity (trend-line lows, unfilled daily gaps, etc.). This locks in a win while maintaining upside exposure.

Size Down in High Volatility; Let Points Do the Work

When the market is moving 200–400 points per day, Desi reduces contract size so that the same dollar risk applies. This prevents account blowups during volatile sessions while allowing him to capture larger point moves (e.g., 50 points of draw-down becomes manageable).

Two-Loss Rule: Stop Trading for the Day

If Desi takes two consecutive losses, he stops trading for the day. If he wins one and loses one, he allows himself a third attempt. This rule protects capital and prevents revenge trading during low-probability windows.

Swing Trading: Higher Timeframe Patience

Entry Off Hourly or 4-Hour, Never Below 1-Hour

For swing trades, Desi enters only off the hourly or 4-hour timeframe, never the 15-minute or lower. This ensures the trade is aligned with genuine higher-timeframe moves rather than intraday noise. The wider stop loss and longer hold time justify this discipline.

Mark Multiple Partial Targets: Daily Gaps, Weekly Gaps, Hourly Gaps

Rather than one take-profit, swing trades have multiple partial targets based on unfilled daily, weekly, and hourly fair value gaps. This allows trimming into strength while maintaining exposure to larger moves.

Ignore Intraday Whipsaws; Focus on Multi-Day Context

A swing trade that retraces 40–50 points intraday is noise if the higher-timeframe bias remains intact. Desi ignores these moves and only manages the position if the hourly or 4-hour structure breaks, not on 15-minute or 5-minute chop.

Options Leaps for Long-Term Positions

For swing trades, Desi uses 1–2 month out options contracts (leaps) to reduce daily management stress. This allows him to hold positions through minor retracements without worrying about time decay or intraday volatility.

Long-Term Leap Trading: Monthly/Weekly Context

Monthly Fair Value Gaps and Order Blocks as Macro Targets

On the monthly chart, Desi identifies untapped fair value gaps and order blocks created during bull markets. These become the highest-probability reversal zones for leap positions. For example, during the Trump tariff news, he predicted a specific monthly gap would be the low months in advance.

Accumulate on Monthly Inversion Confirmation

Once a monthly fair value gap inverts (price breaks through and rejects it), Desi begins adding long-term positions. This inversion signals a potential reversal of the macro trend and justifies deploying larger capital into leap options or long-term futures.

Apply Day-Trading Model to Daily Charts Within Macro Bias

Once the monthly/weekly bias is bullish (e.g., post-inversion), every daily chart setup becomes a high-probability day-trade opportunity. The macro context provides conviction, and the daily model provides precise entries and exits.

Volatility Spikes Create Generational Opportunities

During periods of high VIX and macro news (tariff announcements, Fed decisions), the market creates large moves and multiple daily setups. Desi made nearly \$1M in one month during the Trump tariff period by recognizing this volatility spike and applying his model aggressively.

Asset Selection and Session Timing

NQ (Nasdaq 100 Futures) as Primary Instrument

Desi trades NQ almost exclusively because it has sufficient daily volatility to capture 50–150 point moves consistently. He also trades ES (S&P 500) but prefers NQ's movement profile. The model applies to all liquid assets, but he avoids spreading across too many tickers.

All Sessions Tradable When Volatility Is Elevated

Asia, London, and New York sessions all work if the VIX is kicked up and the market is making large swings. When volatility is flat (e.g., summer months), the setup becomes lower probability regardless of session.

Prefer New York Open (10 a.m. ET) for Day Trades

The 10 a.m. ET open marks the start of a new 4-hour candle and often presents the clearest setups. Before 10 a.m., price action is too choppy and lacks directional bias. Desi avoids trading before this time.

Real-World Examples: November Setup and Live Trade

November 2024 Reversal: Daily Gap Inversion to \$27K Day

On November 17, NQ tapped into a daily fair value gap created from the previous week's gap-up. This triggered a bearish inversion on the hourly, which Desi traded down to prior session lows. The trade yielded a \$27K profit on options, demonstrating the model's real-world application.

Continuation Setup: 4-Hour Gap Tap to Relative Highs

In a separate example, NQ tapped into a 4-hour fair value gap created during an overnight move. Desi waited for the 1-minute inversion of a previously respected 5-minute gap, then entered long. The trade captured a 2:1 risk-reward with runners extending to relative equal highs.

Live Trade Walkthrough: ES Short with Draw-Down Management

During a live broadcast, Desi entered an ES short based on a 15-minute bearish fair value gap rejection and equal lows at weekly support. He added to the position while in 40–50 points of draw-down, then trimmed at the first target and let runners go to the new week opening gap. Final profit: \$10K on the options position.

Building Your Own Model: Key Struggles and Solutions

Initial Paralysis: Too Many Concepts, Not Enough Clarity

When Desi first learned ICT, he tried to use every tool at once (gaps, order blocks, liquidity, SMT, etc.), leading to analysis paralysis. He solved this by isolating the two most important elements for his trading: liquidity and confirmation (inversion).

Timeframe Filtering: Stick to Consistent Levels

Rather than jumping between 1-minute, 5-minute, 15-minute, and hourly charts, Desi recommends staying consistent. For swing trades, use daily/4-hour/hourly. For day trades, use 15-minute/5-minute/1-minute. Avoid going too low (5-second charts) or forcing setups across too many timeframes.

Live Testing Over Backtesting

Desi built his model through live testing on prop firm accounts (lower capital risk) rather than pure backtesting. This added psychological pressure and forced him to refine his rules based on real execution, not just historical data.

Confidence Comes From Data, Not Perfection

Desi's win rate is approximately 65%, meaning he loses regularly. But because he has 1,000–2,000 trades of data showing the model works, he trusts it through losing streaks. New traders lack this data and quit too early.

ICT Is Fractal: Adapt to Your Personality

ICT concepts (gaps, inversions, liquidity, order blocks) can be applied at any timeframe and combined in different ways. Ten ICT traders in a room will trade the same setup slightly differently. The key is building a model that resonates with your personality and testing it until you have conviction.

Seasonal and Volatility Patterns

Only a Few Months Per Year Are Highly Profitable

Desi is on offense (actively trading) for only 3–4 months per year when volatility spikes (tariff news, Fed decisions, earnings season). The remaining 8–9 months are defensive, with smaller base-hit profits. The bulk of annual gains come from these few high-volatility windows.

VIX Elevation Signals Setup Probability Increase

When the VIX is elevated and the market is making large swings, the multi-timeframe reversal and continuation setups become much higher probability. Flat VIX periods (like summer 2024) yield fewer tradable setups.

Macro News Events Create Generational Opportunities

Events like tariff announcements or Fed policy shifts create sustained volatility and large daily moves. These periods allow traders to accumulate leap positions and capture multiple high-probability day trades. Desi made nearly \$1M in one month during the Trump tariff period.

Prop Firm Performance and Payout Strategy

Apex Trader Funding: \$900K+ Payouts in 25 Days

Desi achieved over \$900K in payouts from Apex in just 25 days by applying his model during a high-volatility period. Apex allows up to 20 accounts (20K–150K each) with 100% payout approval and 1-day processing, making it ideal for scaling.

Consistency Rules Prevent Overtrading

Prop firm consistency rules (daily/weekly drawdown limits) force traders to size properly and avoid revenge trading. Desi views these rules as beneficial because they align with his two-loss daily stop rule and force discipline.

Multiple Account Strategy for Scaling

Rather than risking one large account, Desi scales by running multiple funded accounts simultaneously. This diversifies risk and allows him to capture more opportunities across different volatility regimes.

Notable quotes

I'm not looking for a 500 point move every single day. I'm looking for a 50, 100, 150 points. — Desi Trades

You need to have a consistent setup that you can trust every single day. And that's only going to happen if you have that data. — Desi Trades

The technical side is a very small part of it. I think the psychology behind it is way more important. — Desi Trades

Action items

Journal every trade with entry reason, timeframe context, and outcome to build a personal dataset of 1,000–2,000 trades for conviction.

Identify the two most important elements for your trading (e.g., liquidity + inversion confirmation) and isolate them from other ICT concepts to avoid analysis paralysis.

Live test your model on a prop firm account (lower capital risk) before deploying real capital; focus on execution and psychology, not just historical backtests.

Mark monthly and weekly fair value gaps and order blocks on your chart; these become your macro reversal zones for leap positions and long-term bias.

Practice the three-layer confirmation (daily sweep → 4-hour inversion → 15-minute confirmation) on paper or demo until you can identify it in real time without hesitation.

Implement a two-loss daily stop rule: if you take two consecutive losses, stop trading for the day to protect capital and prevent revenge trading.

Trim 50% of your position at the first take-profit target, move your stop to breakeven, and let the remaining 50% run to extended liquidity targets (trend-line lows, unfilled gaps).

Size down during high-volatility sessions (200–400 point daily moves) so that the same dollar risk applies; let the points do the heavy lifting rather than increasing contract size.

Focus on the New York open (10 a.m. ET) for day trades; avoid trading before this time when price action is choppy and lacks directional bias.

Identify the current VIX regime and macro context (tariff news, Fed decisions, earnings season); only be aggressive during high-volatility windows; be defensive during flat periods.

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